About Time

By Joshua Sands

INTRODUCTION

Death is the great equalizer. It's a common factor all of humanity shares. It matters not when, or how or why you died. The fact is, you died…just like everyone else. Just like Hitler, just like Gandhi, just like your great grandmother and mine. For some, it was too soon, for others not soon enough. But for most, it was simply "About Time" by Joshua Sands.

Two days ago, the organist at my church died. Doris Mantiglia. 86 years old. Lung cancer. Smoked like a chimney for 69 of those years. At the funeral, everyone hummed their mantra: *She smoked too much. It was about time. She smoked too much. It was about time.*

When a life ends, when the final chapter is entered in the log, our final measure is whether it was about time. We take three bits of data to determine this. Name, age, cause of death. If the death is considered early, it's tragic. Bruce Mickem, 38, aneurysm. What a shame! But if, as in poor Doris' case, it was about time, then there is nothing more to say. It was simply time. All of this psychobabble about how it's the journey that counts. No one remembers the stories. They remember the final destination. The journey is nothing. It's a page 10 story in a small town paper. We merely measured the journey in years. *How far did you make it? Well, that's about as far as most people.* Racing toward nothing. A journey with a finish line no one can cross.

Three bits of data: name, age, cause of death. Anna Kinder, 92, liver cancer. Kevin Harpring, 65, heart disease. Ty Ackerman, 42, drunk driver.

When I attempted to uncover my heritage - the legacy of my birth parents,

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I was looking for the journey, but all I found was the final destination. Phil Gregory, 26, gun shot wound to the head. Melissa McClish, 20, died in child birth.

The journey wasn't even a page 10 story.

Indeed, I am one of the selfish. I grew up with two loving parents, yet longed for two more. If that makes me a jerk, so be it. I suppose you're tired of the sob stories: *Oh, it's so terrible. I'll never know where I really came from. Something just feels out of place.* But for me, something was missing. The story. I could have grown up with my adopted parents - mom and dad, but let's call them Jean and Steve because I need to detach them - and been solidly content if I just knew the story. How did I become an orphan? Tell me more than the three bits of data. No matter what anyone argues, that data does not stand on its own.

The beauty of death is that, if you desire, you can determine the number of people at your funeral. There's a curve that's undeniable. If you're an infant, you get a dozen people tops. Your death is too tragic to put on display. You're attendance increases dramatically as you enter school. If you go to college close to your hometown, you peak out. Tons at that funeral. College friends and high school friends alike. Add some church members, maybe an old fast-food boss or two, and they'll all have a good cry. Unless you did something stupid like a drug overdose, in which case all bets are off

You continue to have a decent turn-out at the funeral for a few decades after that. Once you hit 50, your death no longer has the shock factor. Subtract a dozen or two. By the time you hit 60, your peers start dying. Subtract a dozen or two. 70, 80, 90, it's about time. Still, attendance is about the same. People die, but you enter retirement homes. People who you sat with at dinner once now will speak at your funeral and dub you inspirational. Don't live past 90, though. After that,

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everyone dies. You get your kids who have likely moved far away from home and some grandchildren waiting for the reading of the will. That's about it. No tears either. After all, it was more than about time. Did my parents have a funeral? Were they married? How many people came? Death in childbirth. Add three dozen. Tragic.

I find myself driving to San Francisco. Not exactly an easy drive from Indiana, but it's the summer and college break lasts for another six weeks. Besides, I tell myself if I don't get any information, I've at least heard there's some great bars there. Why San Francisco? It's where the birth certificate is dated. Why didn't I call? Because there isn't a computerized option for " If you know anything about the lives of Phil and Melissa, press 1."

I arrive at a hospital near North Beach and the hospital employees tell me they can give me a COPY of the birth certificate and the names and ages of both parents, who, they inform me like it's some sort of SkyTracker Weather bulletin, are both deceased.

"Phil Gregory, 26, gunshot wound to the head. Melissa McClish, 20, died in child birth," the nurse says.

"Yes, I know. But I want to know more."

"More? What for? They're dead."

"I don't know. Maybe I'd like to know what they liked to do on a Saturday afternoon, or whether they were in love, or whether I inherited my red hair from my mother or from my father. .. "

"Well, I see you have quite an investigation on your hands. Happy snooping! "

Snooping? This is *my* life.

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There is a fourth piece of data that is infrequently used, but can be thrown in for dramatic effect. Irony. If your death is ironic considering the life you lived, you get the fourth dimension. Like Natalie Wood. Scared of the water all her life. Death by drowning. Natalie gets the fourth dimension. Bear Bryant. Alabama football coach for four decades. Says he'll die if he stops coaching. Months after retirement, the Old Bear kicks the bucket. Fourth dimension for him. Why does irony warrant the additional information? Because even if it was "about time," there is something about being able to predict the time that spooks us. Spookiness warrants the fourth dimension.

Did mom die in a spooky way? Maybe she said "This babies gonna be the death of me." That counts. Maybe she had dark dreams where she envisioned a doctor giving her an epidural, then hearing a baby crying, and then the brightest light she'd even seen. That would definitely count. If this were a movie, it'd be nighttime right now. I'd be pulling my Blue Taurus up to the front of a two-story frame house of a person I believed would have all the answers. Instead, it's 92 degrees at 1:30 in the afternoon as I knock on the apartment door of Francesca Stephenson, mother of Melissa McClish. Again, different last names. I guess it didn't matter just makes the story even more convoluted. She lives on a bad part of Market Street - not the place you want to be.

Francesca was a woman in her early sixties. Graying in every place except her eyebrows, which were still a stern black, letting people know exactly when and how she was concerned.

"My name is Chris. Chris Tyree," I say bluntly, as if I know there is no way to dull the news I was about to say.

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"Nice to meet you Chris Tyree-did you come over to look at the apartment? They said someone would be by to -"

"Melissa was my mother. ... Melissa ... your daughter. .. "

"Oh," she said with half the energy she once had. "Oh, then you're not here to see the apartment."

"No, Mrs. Stephenson. I'm not."

"I'm supposed to fill in the blanks here, aren't I?"

"Are you able?"

"We'll find out, won't we?"

See, people misconstrue my issues. They think I'm obsessed with heritage. I'm not. I don't even realize that Francesca Stephenson is my grandmother. Doesn't even cross my mind to call her Nan, much less want to. People also think I'm obsessed with dying. Like the reason I want to know about my parents is because I knew they died in tragic ways. That's not it either. I'm obsessed with the final tale of the tape. The three measures that tell the story. When the three measures don't tell the story, I want to know more. So often, the measures suffice. Laura Bancroft, 51, heart attack. *She was overweight. It was about time.* Cam Fox, 99, died of natural causes one day before his 100th birthday. *How ironic.* Samantha Stevens, 65, breast cancer. James Carter, 71, urinary tract infection. Hey, it happens.

I imagine myself clairvoyant. I can envision a person's death. My friend, Kristen Carpenter, 82, liver cancer. The dentist, Ryan Overhouse, 60, stroke. The grocery store clerk, Tricia Drake, 21, malaria. *You thought that overseas exchange program was a good idea. You thought 'wrong.*

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Do people become clairvoyant when they are about to die? Was my father playing Russian Roulette when he clicked the trigger and had this tenth of a second when he thought *My God, this is it?* Did my mother scream when she was having me? Right before she died, did she ponder the question: *Is this child worth it?* If she did, what was her answer?

Francesca insists on serving tea to tell this story. I don't drink tea. Today, I drink tea.

"Do you want to ask questions or shall this old woman spin a yarn?" she said.

Speechless, I reply: "Spin away."

For the next 45 minutes, fill-in-the blank sentences become stories. Stories become narratives. Narratives become novels in my mind as I cognitively add and embellish what it must have been like. Phil, I mean Dad's, story still had the mystery. He was no good, never was. Drug rings, strip clubs and dirt bikes. That was his life. One night Melissa came to his place to find him sitting in his Laz- E-Boy chair, bleeding out both of sides of his head. Could have been a drug debt. A gambling debt. A jealous girlfriend - he had several of those, reported Francesca. In my mind, I thought. *OK, father's a bum.* Any hope for mom?

Mom was something different. Granted, grandmothers always think so, but Francesca would pin the medal of honor on her even now. Very creative. An artist. State champion swimmer. *None of that rubbed off on me,* I thought. Phil had been her haphazard attempt at rebellion.

"Everyone dates a loser," Francesca argued, "and Philip was her rotten apple."

After Philip was found dead, little Melissa was left with a gaping hole in her

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life. No one close to her had died before. No one. That hole was filled by pregnancy. I became her lifeline. Not to Phil - but to a better world that was once within her grasp. The doctor had warned her it was high risk. Melissa said she would rather die than give me up. Prophetic. A fourth dimension.

Francesca said she pleaded with Melissa to reconsider. "If she didn't, she would die. We all knew that," Francesca murmured. "Biggest mistake she ever made was - no offense."

"None taken." I said it with a remarkably honest tone. I meant it.

"She made her choice, I suppose."

I couldn't speak. I asked if I could come back and hear the rest tomorrow. Francesca complied.

All my life I looked for the story behind the story. Melissa McClish, 20, died in childbirth. There had to be more. Never once did I stop to consider it a choice that could be made. It was merely a tragedy that could not be avoided. Now I knew better.

She made her choice. My mother made a heroic, honorable choice. A choice I must now live up to. What was I doing in California? I had a life to live that had been bartered for. An odd, renewed energy tingled my spine.

Melissa McClish, 20, died giving life. What would my story be? Would it have a fourth dimension?

We all have a fourth dimension. Sometimes it's evident. Other times, you have to take a road trip to decipher it. Three things are remembered. Four things matter.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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